Elsewhere in this kerchief-sized city, there are more kitschy statuary and heritage dupes. As far back as in 2013, the city had got a park—one of Dhariwal's first pet projects—that boasted replicas of the seven wonders in the world (there's a similar one in Ajmer, by the way, which now faces the risk of demolition after a rap by the National Green Tribunal). There's an old bronze of Maharana Pratap, and Vivekananda, Gandhi, Nehru, Patel and Indira Gandhi duly get their pride of place too. Tall 'rocket launchers' worth Rs 38 crore adorn the Aerodrome Circle. A 21-metre-long ship replica is docked at the Thermal Crossing. A 65,000 sq. ft artificial hill is being built somewhere, with a glass restaurant on top. At a congested junction stands a 22-metre-tall—that is, a full-sized model—of the Kirti Stambh of Chittorgarh Fort. Two huge sculptures loom menacingly at underpasses elsewhere in the city.


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Welcome to the new Kota, the coaching city that's imparting new lessons in profligacy, which has cost the government Rs 5,200 crore in total so far. Somewhere on the riverfront is a huge Nehru face, into which you can climb to look out through his eyes. If those who executed this expensive, controversial spectacle had actually done that, they may have seen their own grave folly. For, no meaningful objective is tied to this 'renovation' extravaganza. No vision for job creation accompanies it, no long-term view on environmental renewal dignifies it. The anguish is palpable among those who live by the river. Most don't have access to a proper sewage system. It was routine for their vehicles to get stuck in open drains; now some of these are choked due to the project debris. Dirty water seeps through their floors and floods lanes. The only solace—the river and its breeze—is now blocked by stone. All this while an agency will be paid nearly Rs 150 crore for the riverfront's upkeep for five years.

Dhariwal argues that it's all for Kota's progress. "The entire project is aimed at making it a tourist destination, which will help boost the city's economy," he says. That argument isn't exactly new, many cities have seen lavish makeovers in recent years aimed at boosting their tourism potential. Except, in the case of Kota, logic seems to have been thrown out the window. The first phase of the Sabarmati Riverfront project, for instance, which roughly cost Rs 1,000 crore, was publicly discussed when it was conceived 50 years ago, and the Gujarat government has a strategy in place to recover that cost. No such plans seem to vindicate the overall spending in Kota. The Rs 900 crore Kashi-Vishwanath Dham project, too, passes muster in terms of practicality—Kashi, or Varanasi, has its unique place on India's tourism map given its significance as one of the most important pilgrimage cities. Kota on the other hand, lying on Rajasthan's eastern fringes, isn't exactly on anyone's list except the annual stream of some 150,000 coaching students. It does not have a five-star hotel. An airport has been pending for years. "Kota is not Kashi," says a state minister who raised the issue in various cabinet meetings. And environmentalist Ravindra Singh Tomar says, acidly, "If replicas could attract tourists, there would be a Taj in every town."

"THE CRORES BEING SPENT ON COSMETIC EFFECTS IN KOTA ARE AT THE COST OF BASIC INFRASTRUCTURE ELSEWHERE," SAYS CONGRESS'S OSIAN MLA DIVYA MADERNA

Many others point to the neglect of existing structures. Says Kota-based historian Firoz Ahmed: "It's tragic to see such spending on replicas when the government does not conserve original monuments, like our Garh palace." In fact, if anything, the riverfront construction has worsened things, damaging the naturally rocky riverside and its ecology, say activists. An artificial water body on the riverfront is already seeing signs of water hyacinth, an invasive plant species. There's no meat waste disposal system for around 300 butchers living in the neighbourhood. Krishna Dutt Sharma, 40, a fruit seller near the